

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump announced a temporary pause to the operation to [guide commercial ships](#) out of the **Strait of Hormuz**. He said “great progress” had been made toward a “complete and final agreement” with Iran. However Mr Trump said the American blockade of Iranian ports would continue. Marco Rubio, the secretary of state, said that Operation Epic Fury—America’s and Israel’s military campaign in Iran—was over. Meanwhile the **United Arab Emirates** said it intercepted missile and drone attacks from Iran for a second day.

Iran’s foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, arrived in **Beijing** to discuss the conflict in the Middle East with his Chinese counterpart. [China](#) has so far offered Iran little by way of serious economic, diplomatic or military aid, but Mr Araghchi will hope his trip can garner more support. Mr Trump also plans to visit the country for a high-stakes state visit from May 14th.

Asian stockmarkets hit record highs, buoyed by hopes of an end to the war in Iran and by booming demand for Asian-made chips. South Korea’s [Kospi index](#) surged by 6.8%. Shares in Samsung Electronics, the country’s most valuable company, rose by as much as 15%, helping it reach a market value of \$1trn for the first time.

Russian bombs killed at least 20 people and wounded dozens across several cities in **Ukraine**. The attacks came before the start of a two-day ceasefire declared by Vladimir Putin to observe a public holiday marking Russia's victory in the second world war. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, had proposed another open-ended ceasefire set to begin hours after the strikes, which he called "absolutely cynical".

Britain's long-term borrowing costs hit their highest level since 1998. Investors worry that the crisis in the Strait of Hormuz will result in a long period of high inflation. Thirty-year gilt yields rose by 0.19 percentage points to as much as 5.79%; ten-year yields climbed to 5.11%, just below a recent 18-year high, as investors bet that the Bank of England will raise interest rates.

America's **Securities and Exchange Commission** proposed scrapping a requirement for public companies to report **quarterly earnings**, instead allowing them to file twice a year. Mr Trump [floated the idea](#) last year and during his first term. The regulator's chair said the "rigidity" of the current rules may be inhibiting businesses and investors. The SEC will vote on the rule after a 60-day public-comment period.

Five **publishers**, including Hachette and Macmillan, filed a class-action lawsuit against **Meta**, accusing the technology giant of lifting [copyrighted material](#) from pirated websites to train its artificial-intelligence platform, Llama. Meta said that using copyrighted text for this purpose is "fair use" and that it would fight the lawsuit "aggressively". Authors have previously sued the company for similar reasons.

Figure of the day: €150bn (\$176bn), what the European Union's reporting requirements and other paperwork cumulatively cost European businesses each year, according to the bloc's statistics agency. [Read about](#) the EU's overregulation of companies.



Photograph: Getty Images

The G7's trade dilemma

Donald Trump's trade war continues to unsettle the world economy. After a surprisingly strong year in 2025, when demand for AI-related goods like chips caused global trade to grow by nearly 5%, the outlook has darkened. Oxford Economics, a consultancy, expects goods trade to grow by just 2.5% this year. [Tariffs](#) are the main culprit. In America more than 60 Section 301 investigations (the legal mechanism by which levies are imposed) are under way. Last week Mr Trump threatened to raise tariffs on European cars to 25%.

On Wednesday trade ministers from the G7, a club of the world's largest rich democracies, meet in France. They will discuss China's industrial overcapacity, fragile critical-mineral supply chains and the future of the World Trade Organisation. Yet the world's largest economy shows little appetite for co-operation. After a fruitless WTO meeting in March, America's trade envoy dismissed the body as irrelevant. The G7 may seek co-ordination. America has, thus far, chosen confrontation.



Photograph: Getty Images

An unhappy birthday for Germany's government

One year ago Friedrich Merz took office as Germany's chancellor. The coalition he formed, which united his conservative bloc with the Social Democrats, was a coupling of convenience rather than love. But the parties' leaders seemed committed to working together to lift the country from the economic doldrums in which it had long languished. An early decision to [boost defence](#) and infrastructure spending impressed allies and markets.

But the government marks its first birthday in miserable shape. Both parties have lost ground in polls since last year's election. The populist-right Alternative for Germany has opened up its first-ever meaningful lead. Mr Merz, who has lately been embroiled in a [nasty spat](#) with Donald Trump, enjoys an approval rating of just 13%. The parties' endless bickering over domestic reforms has led some to speculate whether their coalition might collapse. And with bigger battles to come over taxes and pensions, it is hard to see the mood improving.



Photograph: EPA

Another Epstein deposition in Congress

On Wednesday Howard Lutnick, America's commerce secretary, will testify before the House Oversight Committee about his relationship with Jeffrey Epstein. The deposition, which takes place behind closed doors, is part of a broader inquiry into Epstein, which seeks to uncover how the dead sex offender grew to be so wealthy and well connected, and how he [evaded accountability](#) for so long.

Members will probably grill Mr Lutnick over his claim to have cut contact with Epstein in 2005, after the financier was first investigated for soliciting underage sex. Documents released by the Department of Justice instead suggest that the two men were in touch years later. In 2012, when Mr Lutnick ran Cantor Fitzgerald, a brokerage and investment bank, they had lunch on Epstein's island in the Caribbean.

The committee has already questioned a number of politicians and high-profile people, some of whom are close to Donald Trump, over their [links to Epstein](#) to understand who may have been complicit in his crimes.



Photograph: Shutterstock

Is the fake-meat industry cooked?

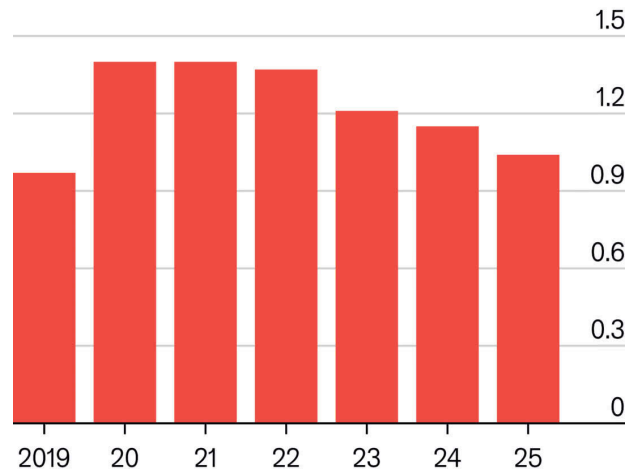
Investors may feel queasy when Beyond, a maker of meat-free burgers, reports quarterly earnings on Wednesday. Since the company went public in 2019 its market value has plummeted from almost \$4bn to less than \$450m. The company has forecast revenues of \$57m-59m for the first quarter of 2026, a decline of up to 17% year on year.

Beyond is suffering because consumers' behaviour has changed. Some are increasingly [reluctant to fork out](#) for plant-based alternatives to meat, which cost more than the real thing. Others are put off by long ingredient lists and complicated production processes, which makes them ultra-processed foods.

However, Beyond is hoping that [the rise of high-protein diets](#) will have more consumers licking their lips. It now calls itself a “Plant Protein Company”, displays its protein content prominently on its packaging and recently launched a line of canned protein drinks. But that has not bulked up sales yet.

Leaving the feast

United States, sales of plant-based meat, \$bn



Source: Good Food Institute



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Andy Summers was the guitarist of which British rock band?

Tuesday: John Fogerty was the main songwriter of which rock group?

*Being entirely honest with oneself
is a good exercise.*

Sigmund Freud